

Pamukkale Hot Springs

Staircaselike terraces of hot springs in southwest Turkey



Pamukkale, which means “cotton castle” in Turkish, evokes a sense of awe due to its white landscape and turquoise pools—arranged in a series of steps, or terraces—that carry water from hot springs.

Travertine steps

Pamukkale’s terraces are composed of travertine, a bright white substance made from calcium carbonate deposited by water from the hot springs. There are 17 springs with temperatures ranging from 95 to 207°F (35 to 97°C). For thousands of years, water that has percolated deep into Earth’s crust and been heated there has re-emerged near the top of a 330-ft (100-m) high hill. As it flows downhill, it passes through a series of pools lined by travertine. The mineral-rich pools are reputed to have health-giving properties.

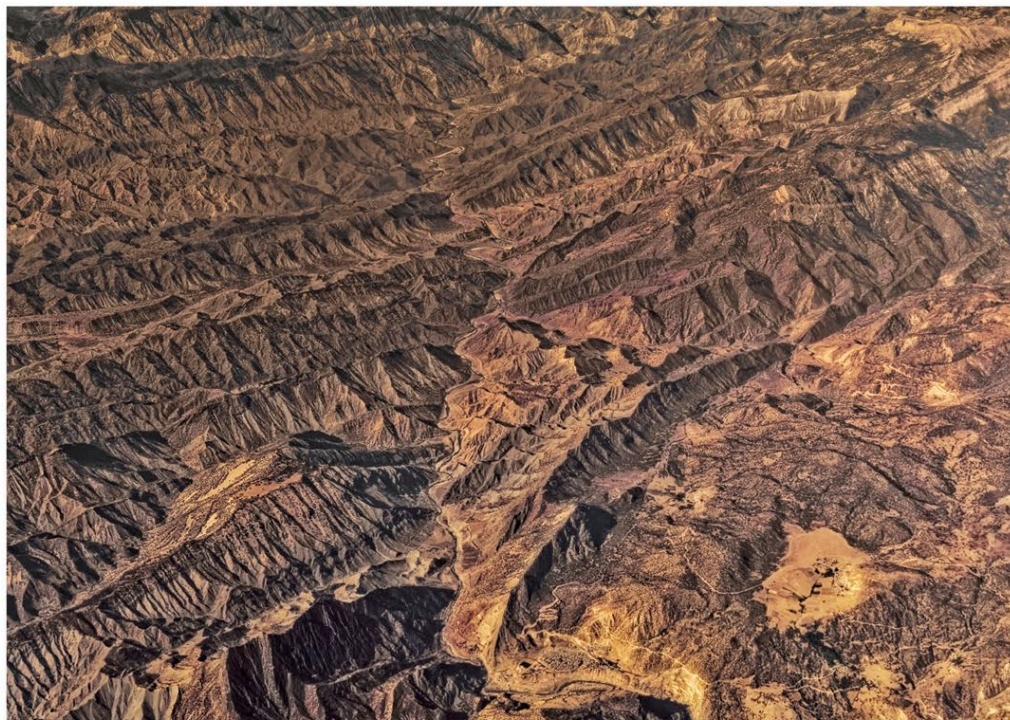
▷ TERRACED POOLS

This area of stepped pools at Pamukkale is 215 ft (65 m) long and 90 ft (27 m) wide. It has around 20 levels, and its pools contain water at about 97°F (36°C).



The Zagros Mountains

An imposing natural barrier running through the Middle East, which displays evidence of the ongoing effects of a tectonic plate collision



The Zagros is the largest mountain range in Iran, also extending into parts of Turkey and Iraq. Some sections rise above 13,000 ft (4,000 m) and are permanently snow-capped, with the highest peak being Ghash Mastan at 14,550 ft (4,435 m). Wild and mostly semiarid, the Zagros started forming around 30–25 million years ago when two tectonic plates—the Arabian Plate and the Eurasian Plate—collided, resulting in the folding of underlying rock layers. A sizable amount of deformation is still occurring today as a result of this collision, and the region is subject to frequent earthquakes.

◁ RIPPLED EARTH

Its many parallel ridges give the Zagros a wavelike appearance.

▷ NIGHT FEEDER

A nocturnal predator and scavenger, the striped hyena occurs in small numbers throughout the Zagros. It features prominently in Middle Eastern folklore.

